Business Letter Writing





Points to remember:

- Plan your letter before you start writing to make sure it says everything you want to say and says it in a logical sequence.

- The layout and presentation of your letter is important as they give the reader the first impression of the firm's efficiency.

Points to remember:

- Ask yourself if the letter represents your organization in a correct way.
- Accuracy is important. Pay special attention to titles, names and addresses, prices and specifications, enclosures.
- Include just the right amount of information in your letter.

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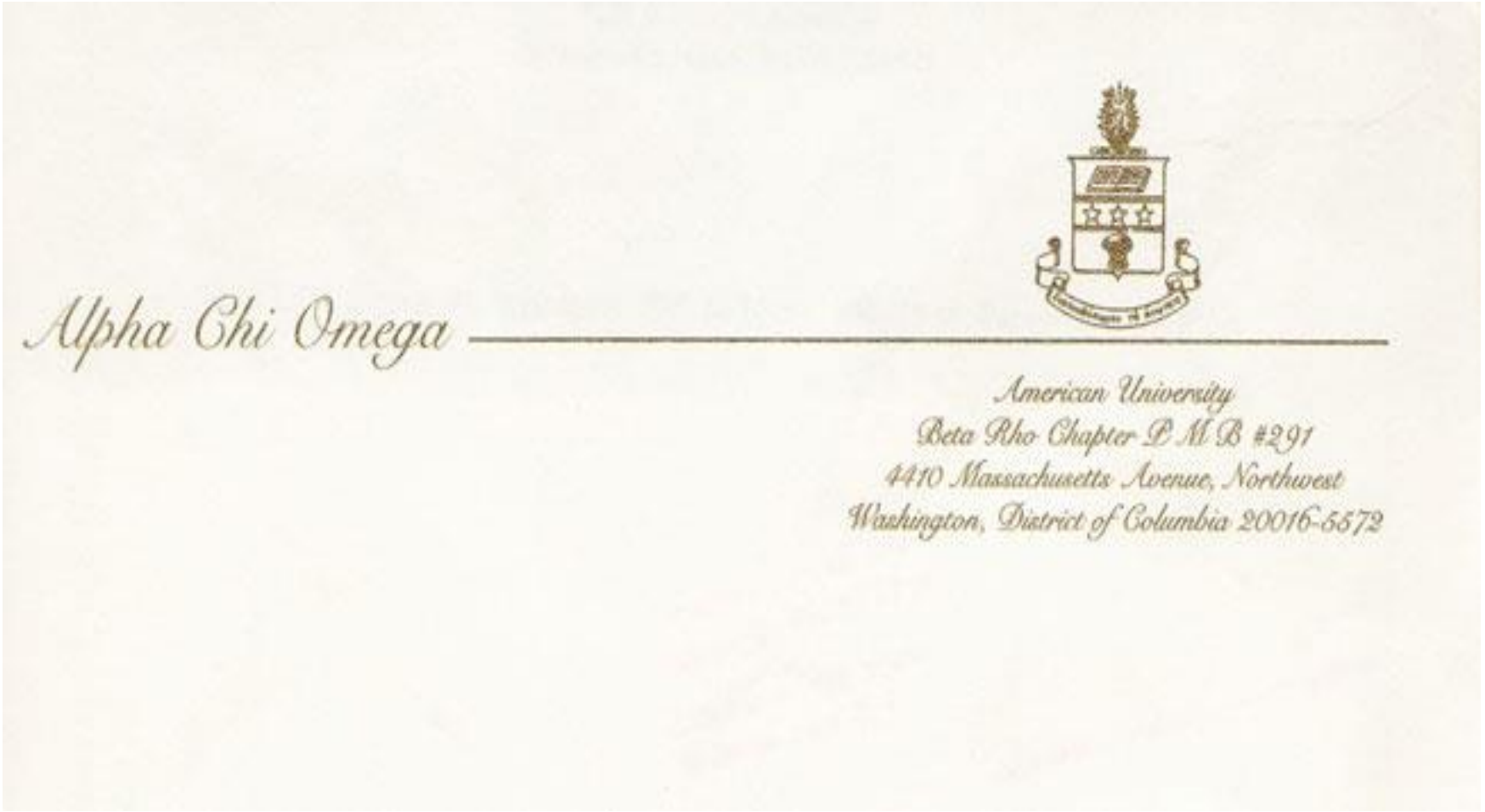
- Use a simple but polite style of language. Beware of idioms.

- Your letter should be clear. Take care with abbreviations and figures.

Elements of a business letter

- letterhead or return address,
- date,
- inside address,
- salutation,
- subject,
- body or text,
- complimentary close,
- signature,
- name and title lines,
- enclosure line (optional)

Letterhead


Alpha Chi Omega
American University
Beta Rho Chapter ΔΧΩ #291
4410 Massachusetts Avenue, Northwest
Washington, District of Columbia 20016-5572

Date

The date is written bellow the sender's address - separated from it by a space.

- Two most common forms:

November 27, 2009 (AmE)

27 November 2009 (BrE)

- The month is never abbreviated, the day is never spelled out, and endings for numbers (27th) are not usually used.
- The shortened date can also be used:

11/27/2009 (AmE)

27/11/2009 (BrE)

Inside address

The address of the recipient:

Name

Position

Soundsonic Ltd.

25 Warwick House, Warwick Street,

Forrest Hill,

London SE23 1JF

UNITED KINGDOM

- Always on the left

- The recipient's name is followed by the position, company's name, the department or division, the street address, city postal code and country (optional).

Salutation

Example:

Dear Sir,

Dear Sirs,

Dear Madam,

Dear Sir or Madam,

Dear Mr. James,

- Should be written below the address and with a space of one or two lines before the body of the letter.
- It is followed by a comma (,) or a colon (:).

Subject title

Example:

SUBJECT: New Office Policy

The subject title:

- Provides a further reference,
- Saves introducing the subject in the first paragraph,
- Immediately draws attention to the topic of the letter,
- Allows the writer to refer to it throughout the letter,
- Quickly identifies the purpose of the letter,
- Should be only ONE line.

Body of the letter

Deals with:

- how much **information** to give,
- how to **plan** a letter,
- what sort of **style** to use,
- how to make a letter as **clear, informative and accurate** as possible.

Length

The length depends on:

- the subject of the letter
- the style and the language used.

The right length includes the right amount of information.

Sequence

- All the necessary points should be made in a logical sequence.
- Each piece of information linking with the previous one in a pattern that can be followed.
- SO, put the ideas and information in logical order.

Style

- Avoid slang, jargon, buzz words, and elitist language.
- Avoid the passive voice. Use the active voice and active verbs.
- Be specific. State the facts.
- "**We**"-s should be used when speaking on behalf of your company or a group of associates.

First paragraph:

- State the **main idea** in the first or second sentence of your letter.
- These sentences should catch the reader's eye and get him to react to your letter.

In the first paragraph you will:

- Thank your correspondent for his letter (if replying),
- State the purpose of the letter

Second paragraphs:

It is the main part of the letter.

It is concerned with :

- points that need to be made,
- answers you want to give or
- questions you want to ask.

Final paragraph:

When closing the letter ….

- Encourage further enquiries and correspondence,
- Mention that you look forward to be hearing from the person soon.
- Important issues from the previous paragraphs may be restated.

Complimentary close

Example: ***Yours sincerely,Yours faithfully,***

- If the letter begins with ***Dear Sir, Dear Sirs, Dear Madam,*** **or** ***Dear Sir or Madam***, *it* will close with ***Yours faithfully***.
- If the letter begins with personal name (***Dear Mr. James***), it will close with ***Yours sincerely***.
- **Leave two-three line** between the body of the letter and the complimentary close.

Signature

- The signature block consists of your handwritten signature, typed name and your position in the firm.

- The handwritten signature should be in between the complimentary close and the typed name.

Enclosures

- Small enclosures (checks, folded flyers, business cards) are placed inside the folds of the letter.

Enclosure line

Enc: or Encl: Bill of lading (5 copies)

- Enclosures may include leaflets, CVs
- They can be mentioned at the bottom of the letter after *Enc*. or *Encl*.
- If there are a number of documents, then it should be listed.